

24 Judah

The brother who sold Joseph, was humbled, and offered his own life for Benjamin: father of the royal tribe.

Judah was Jacob's fourth son by Leah. His name means "praise," and his tribe would give Israel its kings, from David to the line of Jesus. But his early story is not praiseworthy. It was his idea to sell Joseph as a slave, and he treated his widowed daughter-in-law Tamar unjustly until she exposed him. Yet Judah changed. Years later in Egypt, when Benjamin faced slavery, Judah offered to take his place, and Joseph could hold back no longer. His life shows how God can reshape a selfish man into a leader who gives himself for others.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Yehudah</i> , linked to "praise" (Genesis 29:35)
Family	Fourth son of Jacob and Leah
Wife	The daughter of Shuah, a Canaanite (Genesis 38:2)
Sons	Er, Onan, Shelah; twins Pharez and Zarah by Tamar
Key places	Dothan; Adullam and Timnath; Egypt; Goshen
Key people	Jacob, Joseph, Benjamin, Tamar
Main passages	Genesis 37:26–27; 38; 43–44; 49:8–12
New Testament	Matthew 1:2–3; Hebrews 7:14; Revelation 5:5

"The sceptre shall not depart from Judah, nor a lawgiver from between his feet, until Shiloh come; and unto him shall the gathering of the people be."

Genesis 49:10, KJV

The life of Judah

Genesis gives few ages for Judah. Tradition dates Jacob's move to Egypt c. 1876 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC. Genesis 38 may overlap Joseph's story.

In Haran	● Born to Leah Leah says, "Now will I praise the LORD: therefore she called his name Judah." <i>Genesis 29:35</i>
Near Dothan	● Sells Joseph Judah asks, "What profit is it if we slay our brother?" and suggests selling him instead. <i>Genesis 37:25–28</i>
At Adullam	● Leaves his brothers He marries the daughter of Shuah, a Canaanite; they have Er, Onan and Shelah. <i>Genesis 38:1–5</i>
Near Timnath	● Confronted by Tamar Shown his own signet and staff, he admits, "She hath been more righteous than I." <i>Genesis 38:6–30</i>
During the famine	● Pledges himself for Benjamin "I will be surety for him; of my hand shalt thou require him." <i>Genesis 43:1–14</i>
In Joseph's house	● Offers his life He asks to remain a slave in Benjamin's place, and Joseph reveals himself. <i>Genesis 44:14–45:3</i>
c. 1876 BC <i>Into Egypt</i>	● Leads the way to Goshen Jacob sends Judah ahead to Joseph to show the way. <i>Genesis 46:12, 28</i>
Jacob's deathbed	● Receives the royal blessing Jacob calls him a lion's whelp and promises the sceptre will not depart from him. <i>Genesis 49:8–12</i>

Key activities

Genesis 49:10 is debated. "Shiloh" may be a name or title for a coming ruler, or may mean "until he comes to whom it belongs." Jews and Christians have long read the verse as a promise of the Messiah.

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- I Proposed selling Joseph.** He talked the brothers out of murder but into selling Joseph for twenty pieces of silver. *Genesis 37:26–28*

 - 2 Joined in deceiving Jacob.** The brothers let their father believe Joseph was dead. *Genesis 37:31–35*

 - 3 Went his own way.** He left his brothers and married a Canaanite woman. *Genesis 38:1–2*

 - 4 Buried two sons.** The LORD took the life of Er, who was wicked, and then of Onan, whose act displeased him. *Genesis 38:7–10*

 - 5 Failed his daughter-in-law.** He sent Tamar home to wait for Shelah but never gave her to him. *Genesis 38:11, 14*

 - 6 Confessed his wrong.** Faced with his own signet, bracelets and staff, he admitted, "She hath been more righteous than I." *Genesis 38:25–26*

 - 7 Spoke plainly to his father.** He insisted they could not return to Egypt without Benjamin, because the governor had warned them. *Genesis 43:3–5*

 - 8 Became surety for Benjamin.** He took full responsibility: "let me bear the blame for ever." *Genesis 43:8–10*

 - 9 Confessed the family's guilt.** Before Joseph he said, "God hath found out the iniquity of thy servants." *Genesis 44:16*

 - 10 Offered himself in Benjamin's place.** "Let thy servant abide instead of the lad a bondman to my lord; and let the lad go up with his brethren." *Genesis 44:18–34*

 - II Guided the family to Goshen.** Jacob trusted him to go ahead and prepare the way. *Genesis 46:28*

 - 12 Was named the royal tribe.** Jacob gave him the sceptre blessing, the promise of lasting rule. *Genesis 49:8–12*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Judah.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:35–50:26	The main account of his life
Ruth 4:12, 18–22	The line from Pharez to David
1 Chronicles 5:2	"Of him came the chief ruler"
Psalm 78:67–70	God "chose the tribe of Judah"
Micah 5:2	A ruler from Bethlehem, "little among the thousands of Judah"
Echo: Exodus 32:31–32	Moses offers himself for his people

New Testament

Matthew 1:2–3	Judah and "Phares" in Jesus' genealogy
Hebrews 7:14	"Our Lord sprang out of Juda"
Revelation 5:5	"The Lion of the tribe of Juda"
Echo: 1 Peter 3:18	Christ suffered, "the just for the unjust"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Compare Judah's words in Genesis 37:26–27 with Genesis 44:33–34. What changed?
2. *Understand:* Why is admitting wrong (Genesis 38:26) often the first step to real change?
3. *Apply:* Where do you need to take responsibility instead of shifting blame?
4. *Apply:* Judah protected the brother his father favored. Who could you stand up for, even at a cost?